far—brokered by Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) leader and Punjab chief minister Bhagwant Mann—with Union ministers Piyush Goyal and Arjun Munda, but they didn't get too far.

This time, though, the BJP-led Centre was better prepared to deal with the protesters, stopping them at the Shambhu and Khanauri borders and preventing the tractor trolleys from reaching the national capital. The Delhi Police has also sealed the borders connecting Uttar Pradesh and Haryana as a last line of defence. Meanwhile, in Chandigarh, the issue is in the high court, with petitioners seeking to stay "all obstructive action by the state" to stop the farmers from reaching Delhi.

All this has left a bad taste at a time when PM Modi and the BJP had thought they had sewn up the support of the agrarian community in the north. Recently, the BJP government had announced the Bharat Ratna to the late farmer leader and ex-PM Charan Singh which had helped rope in his grandson Jayant Chaudhary and his Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD) to the NDA fold (the target being the Jat farmer votes in western UP where the RLD is a key player). The farmers' protest, if it drags on, might affect this alliance too. The political fallout of the protests has already derailed the BJP's parleys with the Akali Dal for an alliance in Punjab, and may further strain ties with ally Dushyant Chautala's Jannayak Janta Party (JJP) in Haryana. The JJP is already sulking as the BJP refused to discuss seat-sharing in Haryana for the Lok Sabha poll.

The Opposition, too, has not missed the opportunity to corner the BJP. West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee promptly backed the farmers while Congress leader Rahul Gandhi paused his Bharat Jodo Nyay Yatra to meet with them. AAP, too, got into the act, refusing a central request to turn a stadium in Bawana on Delhi's outskirts into a temporary jail for the protesters, saying they were the "nation's *annadatas*" and couldn't be treated so shabbily.

THE KEY DEMANDS

- Law guaranteeing (MSP) for all crops, which was a key condition for the farmers withdrawing the 2021 protests
- Justice and compensation for farmers killed in Lakhimpur Kheri incident in 2021 where a Union minister's son allegedly mowed down four farmers
- Withdrawal of all cases against farmers from the 2021 protests; compensation to families of those who died
- Enhanced compensation for land acquired for public projects; 10 per cent of residential plots on land for families of land owners
- Rs 10,000 monthly pension for farmers who are over 60
- The country's withdrawal from the WTO and junking of all free trade agreements
- Scrapping the Electricity (Amendment) Bill, 2020, for fears that the power sector is being increasingly privatised, affecting their subsidies

The challenge for the BJP is magnified as the bulk of the Jat Sikh leaders imported by the party in Punjab in the past two years have not been able to connect with these farmer leaders. Those leading the march this time, such as Sarwan Singh Pandher of the Kisan Mazdoor Sangharsh Committee, Manjit Singh Rai of Bharatiya Kisan Union (BKU)-Doaba, Jagjit Singh Dallewal of BKU (Ekta Sidhupur) and Baldev Singh Sirsa of Lok Bhalai Insaf Welfare Society, are second-tier leaders among the farm unions. The protests have not even had a pan-Punjab effect so far, but if the conflict persists, some feel the anger may spread to Haryana, western UP and Rajasthan. As of now, farmer organisations in these states have only extended moral support.

THE NEGOTIATIONS ARE IN A SPOT BECAUSE SOME OF THE DEMANDS MADE BY THE UNIONS DON'T HAVE EASY ANSWERS

The negotiations are in a spot also because some of the demands made by the unions don't have easy solutions, and often involve state-level tangles—the demand for a monthly pension of Rs 10,000 for old farmers and farm labourers over 60, for example. In the recent assembly polls in Chhattisgarh, the BJP had promised Rs 10,000 annually for landless agricultural labour. But this money has to come from the state coffers. Also look at the key demand from the rather sweeping list (*see box*): a legal guarantee for procurement of all crops at MSP, to be calculated as per the maximal scenario suggested by the Swaminathan Commission in 2004. This calls for adding capital costs (C2) like rent on land to the lesser formula adopted by the Modi regime—A2+FL, which covers all other costs, including family labour. (The challenge is partly that rents vary at the state level.) The unions also seek total farm debt waiver, enhanced compensation for any farmland acquisition, withdrawal of the 2023 Forest (Conservation) Amendment Act, and toss in seemingly unreasonable requests like India withdrawing from the World Trade Organization (WTO). Add to that, justice for the murdered farmers in the 2021 Lakhimpur Kheri incident.

Says Union minister Anurag Thakur, "The protesters should understand that if they continue to add new demands, it will lead to a logjam and resolution will take time. If you talk about India's separation from WTO and ending free trade agreements, if you want to stop the installation of smart meters, demand exclusion on the issue of stubble-burning or talk about keeping out agriculture from the climate issue, these are not decisions that can be taken unilaterally. There are a lot of things at stake here." But the ruling BJP still needs to deal with the conundrum with tact and care—politically and via policy. And they need to do it soon. ■